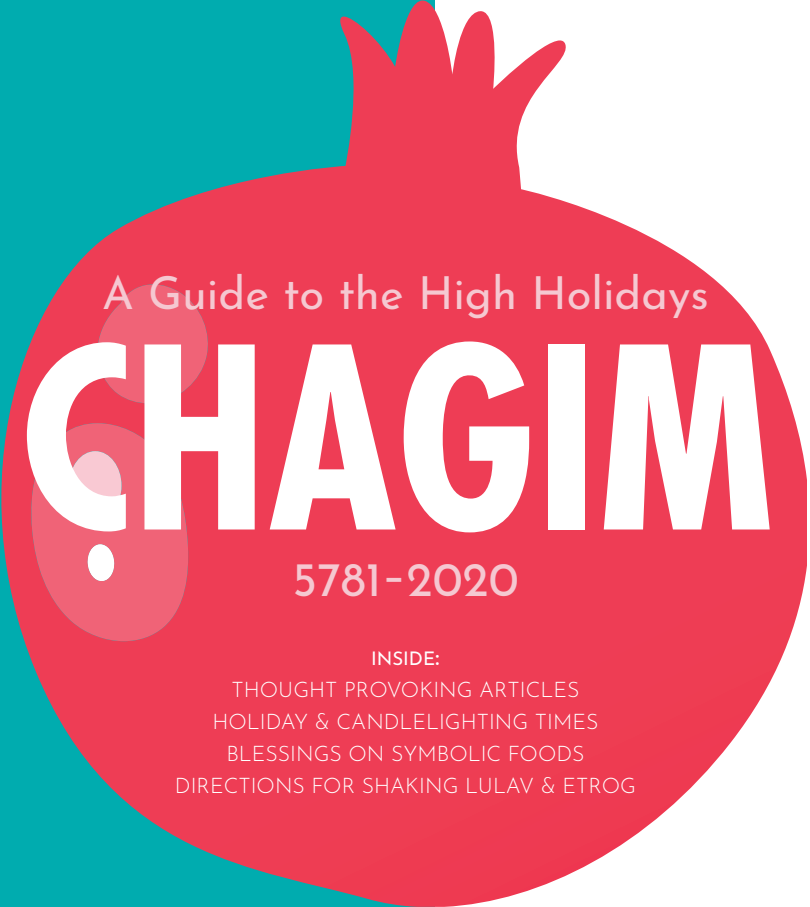




A Guide to the High Holidays

CHAGIM

5781-2020

INSIDE:

THOUGHT PROVOKING ARTICLES
HOLIDAY & CANDLELIGHTING TIMES
BLESSINGS ON SYMBOLIC FOODS
DIRECTIONS FOR SHAKING LULAV & ETROG

Please respect the sanctity of this guide

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A Word from the Rabbi

Dear Friends,

The beginning of a new year is a time to reset and refresh. It's an opportunity to complete the things we may have neglected in the previous year and to move forward.

We are pleased to present you with this guide, which includes practical instructions for celebrating the Tishrei holidays, concepts and other important information.

We hope you will find this guide helpful and we wish you a good and blessed year, a year in which we will merit the immediate Redemption!

May you be inscribed and sealed for a good and sweet year!

Rabbi Nachman Yosef Segal
Shliach of the Rebbe

Before Rosh Hashanah, many Jews would send their name and their mother's name to the Lubavitcher Rebbe along with a request for a good year. The Rebbe would read all the letters at the gravesite of his father-in-law, the previous Lubavitcher Rebbe, and pray on behalf of all of Israel.

Today as well, it is possible to send your requests to the Rebbe's resting place, for blessings for you and all your family members. Write your letter and sign with your name and your mother's name.

On the eve of Rosh Hashanah it is customary to visit the graves of the righteous to pray for a good year. You can visit the Rebbe's Ohel at 226-20 Francis Lewis Boulevard, Cambria Heights, NY, 11411. If you are unable to go in person, you can deliver your letter to your local Chabad House, fax it to 718-723-4444 or email to Ohel@Ohelchabad.org.

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Rochel bas Moshe Z'L Ruimy From the house of Abuchatzera

In merit for blessing and long life:

Zev ben Rivka, Moshe ben Rivka Baila,

Best wishes to Carmel ben Victoria for good and complete health, and his wife Roza Shoshana bat Bronia and the entire Shashua family for long and good life

May Hashem repay them with an abundance of blessing and success
and may they be blessed with a happy and sweet new year!



The Month of Elul

The King IS IN THE FIELD

During these days G-d is close to us; He extends His arms to us to make the coming year better than ever before | **The month of Elul, according to the teachings of the Lubavitcher Rebbe**

What is your first association with the words “month of Elul”?

In the eyes of many, the month of Elul is associated with fear and trepidation. Some adopt a serious, somber mood during this month - after all, the Days of Awe are approaching.

The chassidic approach to Elul is different. Elul is a time of great love, compassion and mercy. During these days G-d is especially close to us. He extends His arms to us, inviting us to turn a new leaf and start off the new year better than ever before.

The Door Is Open

The days of Elul are likened to a time when the king goes out to the fields, to the people, and allows everyone to approach him. While the king is ensconced in his palace, an ordinary person has little hope of approaching him. Only very special people are granted admittance to the royal palace, let alone an audience with the king. But when the king goes out to the field, everyone can approach him and request whatever lies on their heart.

When the king goes out to the field, he abandons the formalities of the royal palace. He greets all his citizens with a friendly smile and listens carefully to their requests. All the people have to do is go out to the field to greet the king.

In the month of Elul, G-d leaves His

“palace.” He reveals Himself to us and shows a shining face to every one of us. He stretches out a loving hand to anyone who sincerely wishes to come close to Him. We can harness this power during the month of Elul to make good resolutions for the year to come.

Opening the heart

Not everyone can feel G-d’s nearness during this month, but our soul definitely senses that G-d is closer to us than usual. This expresses itself in a greater spiritual longing, which stems from our yearning to become close to our Father in heaven.

The month of Elul is also a time of kindness and mercy, and it is appropriate for us to reflect this in our interactions with others - to bless and wish each other a good and sweet year. It is a time to forgive, to make up, to give the benefit of the doubt and find the positive in everyone. The love that G-d showers upon us is reflected back in the love we share with our brethren, His children.

It is up to us to utilize the days of Elul in the best manner possible. It is as if G-d is telling each one of us: I am giving you 29 amazing days to change. If you will only commit yourselves sincerely - you will be able to correct anything that was wrong in the past year and start off the new year on the right foot.



The Month of Elul



What It's All About

🎵 Elul is the 12th and final month of the Jewish calendar and has 29 days. It serves as a time of preparation for the holiday-packed month of Tishrei, which begins with Rosh Hashanah, then the ten days of repentance, followed by Yom Kippur and the joyous holidays of Sukkot and Simchat Torah.

🎵 The name Elul is of Babylonian origin, and means searching. It alludes to the theme of this month, a time of soul-searching and self-examination.

🎵 The month of Elul is mentioned in the Torah for the first time in the Book of Nechemia.

🎵 “A month of mercy and supplication” - One of the ways that Elul is described sums up the theme of this month, when G-d displays His mercy. During this month it is customary to recite Selichot.

🎵 Our sages have found various verses for which Elul is an acronym. One is the verse in Song of Songs, *Ani l'dodi v'dodi li - I am my beloved's and my beloved is mine*. This is the month in which we turn to our “beloved,” our Creator, and G-d, our “beloved” turns to us.

What Do We Do in Elul?

Blow Shofar. All the days of Elul (except for Shabbat and the day before Rosh Hashana) there is a custom to blow the shofar, to arouse us to do teshuvah.

Recite Tehillim. After the morning and afternoon prayers, we recite chapter 27 of Psalms, which begins with the verse: “To David; G-d is my light and my salvation.” We recite this chapter from Rosh Chodesh Elul until Hoshana Rabbah.

Good Wishes. During the month of Elul, we bless each other with the wish for a “ketivah vachatimah tova - good inscription and seal” for the coming year.

Checking tefillin and mezuzot. Once a year it is appropriate to have your tefillin and mezuzot inspected by an expert scribe (sofer) to ensure that they are kosher and no letters are cracked or faded. Please contact your local Chabad center.

Selichot. Starting from Saturday night,

September 12, 2020 and each morning thereafter until Erev Rosh Hashana, we gather in the synagogue for the recital of special prayers to express regret for our past misdeeds and hope for the coming year. Jewish communities of Sephardic origin begin to recite selichot from the 2nd of Elul until Erev Yom Kippur.

Joy. During these days G-d is particularly close to us and therefore these are days of joy. We try to increase in happiness and to do everything with enthusiasm and joy.



Rosh Hashanah

More than Just APPLE & HONEY



On Rosh Hashanah, all of creation is renewed. A new year brings new strengths, new abilities, new possibilities.

For Rosh Hashanah, we shop, invite guests, prepare holiday meals, send out New Year cards and also reserve our seat in the synagogue.

The slew of preparations can leave the impression that this holiday is all about the meals, the new clothing, the new year's wishes and yes, the synagogue.

But all of the above are just manifestations of the holiday, not the essence of the holiday itself. They're like the envelope, the outer covering, which we must peel back to get to the essential meaning of Rosh Hashanah.

Everything Begins Anew

Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur are called the "Days of Awe," because they are a time of judgment. According to our sages, during this time G-d "sits on His throne of judgment" and determines our lot for the coming year. The emphasis on Rosh Hashanah is on prayer and asking G-d for mercy, so that

we merit to be inscribed in the book of life for a good and sweet year.

The teachings of Kabbalah and Chassidut reveal many depths of meaning in Rosh Hashanah. It is a time of renewal, when everything returns to its source. The G-dly energy that sustained all of creation during the past year returns to its source, and on Rosh Hashanah G-d sends forth a new light, one that has never been revealed since creation.

On Rosh Hashanah, all of creation is renewed. Even though it may seem that we are the same as we were last year, it is not so. We are given new strengths, new abilities, new channels and new possibilities. This is expressed in the Rosh Hashanah wish: "Let the past year with its curses end, and a new year with its blessings begin!" because now we are beginning anew.

Crowning the King

In order to be worthy of this new flow



Rosh Hashanah



What It's All About

 Rosh Hashanah is a holiday mentioned in the Torah.

 It is a two-day holiday, on the 1st and 2nd of Tishrei. It begins the “Days of Awe,” the days of

judgment, which conclude with Yom Kippur.

 The name Tishrei is of Aramaic origin and means “beginning.”

and to absorb it properly, we also need to refresh ourselves, particularly in our relationship with G-d. Perhaps in the past year we were too wrapped up in ourselves and forgot our Creator, but on Rosh Hashanah we stand before G-d and accept His kingship anew.

This motif of “crowning” G-d as King of the universe is a central part of the prayers of Rosh Hashanah. It is our central request during these days: “Reign over the entire world with Your glory.”

On Rosh Hashanah we open our hearts to our Creator and say: “You are our King and we are Your servant.”

When we accept upon ourselves anew the Kingship of G-d and crown Him as our King, we make ourselves worthy of receiving His bounty for the coming year, for ourselves and the entire world.

the sound of the shofar breaks through all barriers and pushes away all prosecutors. It reaches directly to the Creator and arouses Him to send forth a new flow of blessings for the new year to each and every one of us.

When the shofar is blown we are enveloped in a spirit of purity and teshuvah. We commit ourselves to be better in the coming year and we promise our Creator to be more faithful to His will and to our purpose on this earth.

This commitment that we take upon ourselves for the coming year is with a spirit of joy. We are fortunate to be servants of G-d and we are full of thankfulness that He has chosen us as His people.

This is the service of Rosh Hashana and in its merit we will be inscribed and sealed for a good and sweet year.

The Heart Cries with the Shofar

The main part of the coronation comes when we blow the shofar. At this elevated moment, when the sound of the shofar cuts through the air, our hearts open. The soul cries out to its Father in heaven and this inner cry rises to the heavens.

According to the teachings of Kabbalah,





Rosh Hashanah: What to Do

Eve of Rosh Hashanah

Friday, 29 Elul, September 18

Do not celebrate alone. It is appropriate to remember those who may have trouble with holiday expenses and help them to celebrate as well. This is in keeping with the verse (Nechemia 8:10): "Eat fat foods and drink sweet drinks and send portions to whoever has nothing prepared, for the day is holy to our L-rd."

Nullification of vows. In the synagogue, after morning prayers, we nullify all vows we may have made over the course of the year unintentionally so that we enter the new year without the burden of unfulfilled promises.

Prayer at the gravesite of tzadikim. Some have the custom to visit the gravesite of tzadikim before Rosh Hashanah to ask them to intercede with G-d on our behalf.

First night of Rosh Hashanah

Friday 29 Elul, September 18

Fire. We leave a fire burning, either on the stove or a long-burning candle, in order to light the candles on the second night of the holiday. It is forbidden to light a new flame on Yom Tov.

Lighting candles. In the evening, before Shabbat and the holiday begins, women and girls light candles. For candlelighting times see page 25.

Recite the following blessings:

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments, and commanded us to kindle the light of Shabbat and the Day of Remembrance.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Good wishes. After the evening prayers on the first night of Rosh Hashanah, we turn to each other and say, "L'shanah tovah tikatev v'techatem – May you be inscribed and sealed for a good year."

Kiddush and holiday meal. We eat a festive meal to celebrate G-d's certain acceptance of our prayers. Before the meal we recite kiddush over wine.

The sixth day, And the heavens and the earth all their hosts were completed. And G-d finished by the Seventh Day His work which He had done, and He rested on the Seventh Day from all His work which He had done. And G-d blessed the Seventh Day and made it holy, for on it He rested from all His work which G-d created to function.

Attention, gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe who creates the fruit of the vine.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has chosen us from among all nations, raised us above all languages, and made us holy through His commandments. And You, Lord our G-d, have given us in love this Shabbat day and this Day of Remembrance, the festival of holy assembly, a day for the remembrance sounding the shofar in love, a holy assembly, commemorating the Exodus from Egypt. For You have chosen us and sanctified us from among all the nations, and Your word, our King, is true and enduring forever. Blessed are You, Lord, King over all the earth, who sanctifies the Shabbat and Israel and the Day of Remembrance.

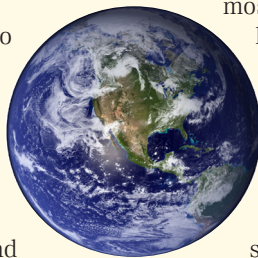
Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.



What happened on Rosh Hashanah?

According to Jewish tradition there were several events that happened on Rosh Hashanah for which it was chosen as the Jewish new year.

Adam was created. According to Jewish tradition, the world was created on the 25th of Elul and it took six days. On the sixth day Adam was created. As soon as he was created, Adam recognized his Creator and called to the other creatures: "Come let us bow and kneel and bless before G-d our Maker." On this day G-d was crowned as King for the first time, and for this reason we gather



every year on this date to celebrate it anew.

The trial of the Akedah. On this day Abraham was tested with his 10th final and most difficult trial. G-d commanded Him to bring his son as a sacrifice. On Rosh Hashanah Abraham ascended Mount Moriah (the future Temple Mount) and bound his son as a sacrifice. At the last moment a voice called out, "Do not stretch out your hand to the boy," and Abraham offered a ram instead. We blow the shofar made from a ram's horn to commemorate the binding of Isaac.

Special foods. On Rosh Hashanah there is a custom to eat traditional foods that denote blessings for the new year. We dip the challah in honey (rather than salt) and eat apples dipped in honey for a sweet year. We also eat a pomegranate and the head of a ram (or fish).

First day of Rosh Hashanah

Shabbat, 1 Tishrei, September 19

Blowing the shofar. When Rosh Hashana falls out on Shabbat, the shofar is not blown.

Kiddush and festive meal. In the afternoon we eat a holiday meal. Before the meal we make kiddush on wine:

This is the meal of the holy Ancient One.

Remember the Shabbat day to sanctify it. Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is Shabbat for the Lord your God; you shall not do any work - you, your son or your daughter, your manservant or your maidservant, or your cattle, or the stranger within your gates. For in six days the Lord made the heavens, the earth, the sea, and all that is in them, and rested on the seventh day-

Therefore the Lord blessed the Shabbat day and made it holy.

Blow the Shofar on the New Moon, on the designated day of our Holy Day. For it is a decree for Israel, a (day of) judgment for

the G-d of Jacob.

Attention, gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Tashlich. When the first day of Rosh Hashana falls out on Shabbat, Tashlich is said on the second day of Rosh Hashana.

Eve of the Second Day of Rosh Hashanah

Motzei Shabbat, 1 Tishrei, September 19

Candle lighting. We light the candles **after** nightfall, when three stars can be seen in the sky. The candles should be lit from a pre-existing flame, as it is forbidden to light a new fire on Yom Tov. Before lighting, a new fruit is placed on the table, and when the Shehecheyanu (granted us life) blessing is made, we have in mind the new fruit. For candlelighting times see page 25.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments, and commanded us to kindle the light of the Day of Remembrance.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Kiddush and festive meal. During kiddush we leave the new fruit on the table and when



we recite Shehecheyanu we keep the fruit in mind. Kiddush is recited on a cup of wine.

Attention, gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe who creates the fruit of the vine.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has chosen us from among all nations, raised us above all languages, and made us holy with His commandments. And You, Lord our G-d, has given us in love, this Day of Remembrance, the festival of holy assembly, a day for sounding the shofar, a holy assembly, commemorating the Exodus from Egypt. For You have chosen us and sanctified us from among all the nations, and Your word, our King, is true and enduring forever. Blessed are You Lord, King over the entire earth, who sanctifies Israel and the Day of Remembrance.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the

universe, who created the lights of fire.

Glance at the festival lights, then continue:

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who makes a distinction between sacred and profane, between light and darkness, between Israel and the nations, between the Seventh Day and the six work days; between the holiness of the Shabbat and the holiness of the Festival You have made a distinction, and have sanctified the Seventh day above the six work days. You have set apart and made holy Your people Israel with Your holiness. Blessed are You, Lord, who makes a distinction between holy and holy.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

We taste the new fruit after kiddush before washing hands. Make the blessing, **Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine**, before eating the fruit. We eat a festive meal but the foods signifying the new year are only eaten the first night.

Special Foods



Apple in honey. We dip an apple in honey and say the blessing: "Blessed are You, L-rd our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the tree." Then we recite the following prayer: "May it be Your will to renew for us a good and sweet year."



Pomegranate. There is a custom to eat a pomegranate, whose many seeds represent the mitzvot of the Jewish people.



Head. Some eat the head of a ram, lamb or fish, to represent our hopes that this year we will be a "head and not a tail."

Various communities have unique customs for special foods to eat on Rosh Hashanah such as dates, peas or cabbage. Their names in Hebrew signify blessings for the new year.

Second Day of Rosh Hashanah Sunday, 2 Tishrei, September 20

Blow the shofar. This is the main mitzvah of the holiday. The shofar is blown in the synagogue in the morning and it is important to listen well. Men, women and children should be present to hear the shofar blown.

Kiddush and festive meal. On the afternoon of the second day, we eat a festive meal. Before the meal, recite the kiddush over a cup of wine.

Blow the Shofar on the New Moon, on the designated day of our Holy Day. For it is a decree for Israel, a (day of) judgment for the G-d of Jacob.

Attention, gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Havdalah. At the conclusion of the holiday, havdalah is recited on a cup of wine. The blessings on the spices and candle are not made.



Days of Teshuvah

Return Again

Why is it called teshuvah, return, and not regret? Why tefillah and not request? Why tzedakah and not donation? An inner glimpse, according to the teachings of the Lubavitcher Rebbe.

During the ten days of repentance we place a special emphasis on three things: teshuvah, tefillah and tzedakah. These three words are unique to the Hebrew language and have no counterpart in other languages.

The process of cleansing from sin is usually referred to as “repentance” turning over a new leaf. In Hebrew the word teshuvah means return - not becoming someone new but returning to a previous state.

When a person stands before his Creator and pours out his heart, this is usually called “beseeching” or “supplication,” synonyms for prayer. The Hebrew word tefillah means to bind or join.

Giving gifts to the poor is described in other languages as “kindness” or “charity.” The Hebrew word tzedakah actually means justice.

The Hebrew word for each concept denotes its true inner meaning. It emphasizes that teshuvah is actually a process of returning to ourselves. Prayer is more than a request but a desire to unite with G-d. And tzedakah is not an undeserved gift - it's a form of justice.

True Desire

When a Jew decides to correct his ways, to become closer to the ways of the Torah and to perform mitzvot with greater care - this is not a new path for him. This is his true way, an expression of who he really is. Every Jew, deep inside the soul, loves G-d, loves the Torah and desires to fulfill it. When he returns to the path of Torah and mitzvot he is simply returning to his true desire, to the person he truly is.

When a person removes the external layers that hide his true identity he reveals that indeed, he is filled with faith; he is filled with a strong desire to serve G-d wholly and completely. He is overflowing with love to G-d, to Torah, to Judaism. He does not need to invent himself anew. He only needs to reveal his essence, his G-dly soul. This is called teshuvah - the process of returning to yourself.

Joining and Connecting

The inner meaning of prayer, likewise, is not request but joining and uniting. When we pray, our soul unites with its source. We express our longing to cleave



The Ten Days of Teshuvah



What It's All About

Days of Teshuvah. The ten days between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur are called the “The 10 Days of Teshuva.” These are the days referred to in the verse, “Seek G-d when He is found, call to Him when He is close.”

Shabbat Shuvah. The Shabbat before Yom Kippur is called Shabbat Shuvah, because of the haftarah read this week which begins with the words “Return, Israel, to Hashem your G-d.” The name of this Shabbat reminds us to prepare for the holy day of Yom Kippur with prayer and repentance.

Pending days. In the Talmud it is written that on Rosh Hashanah there are those who are inscribed and sealed for a good year. Then there are those whose judgment is pending until Yom Kippur. If they utilize those days for repentance, they will be sealed for life.

Teshuvah accepted. During these days G-d readily accepts our teshuvah as long as we take the initiative.

Prayer. During these days we add short passages to our prayer that reflect these themes. These additions are noted in the prayer book.

to G-d's infinite light, the source of our existence.

When we pray the soul is elevated above the physicality of this world and above the petty concerns of the physical body and gives expression to the G-dly soul, an actual part of G-d above.

Tzedakah Is Righteousness

The true meaning of tzedakah is not doing a favor or kindness. Tzedakah means

justice. It's the right thing to do, something we are obligated to do.

This formulation of tzedakah is rooted in the recognition that our money is essentially a deposit that is invested with us so that we use it in the right way. We may think that we earned our money by our wit and hard work. But wealth is actually a blessing given to us by G-d, not to squander on every pleasure and luxury, but to use in an intelligent way, to help the needy and support important causes.

When we give to others and bring light and joy to their lives, this is justice - it's the right thing to do with the wealth we were given.

During these days each of us asks G-d to give us a good and sweet year. G-d does not owe us anything; in which merit can we make all our requests? In the merit of tzedakah. To merit a good year from above we must increase in tzedakah. Then G-d will repay us measure for measure and grant us our heart's desire.

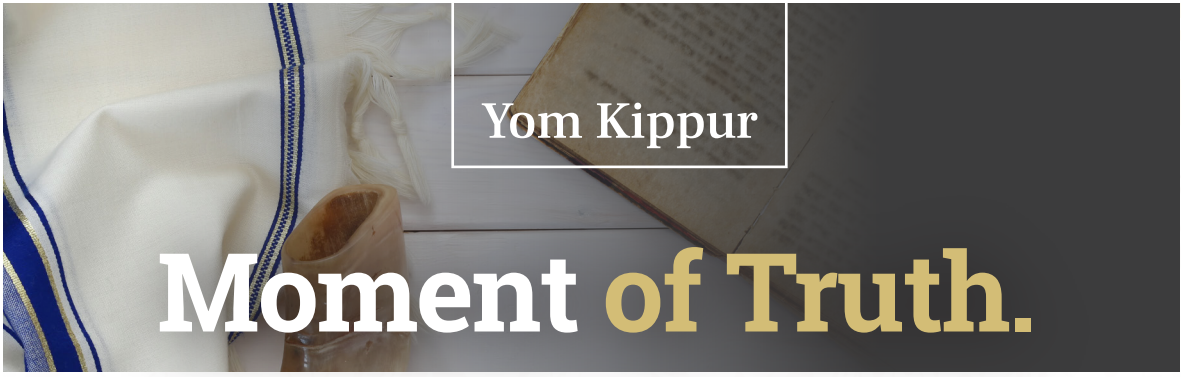
This is how we start off the year on a positive note and merit to be sealed for a good and sweet year, for us and all of Israel.

The Fast of Gedaliah

Monday, 3 Tishrei, September 21

We fast on this day to commemorate the assassination - on Rosh Hashana 3339 (422 BCE) - of Gedaliah ben Achikam, governor of Judea, in the period immediately following the destruction of the first Temple. This painful episode brought an end to Jewish independence in the Land of Israel. Since fasting is not permitted on a holiday, the fast is postponed until the day after Rosh Hashana.





Yom Kippur

Moment of Truth.

Why Yom Kippur is no lie

We often hear the argument that on Yom Kippur, people are fooling themselves. Jews who are not Torah-observant all year suddenly put on their kippahs, go to the synagogue and fast. Isn't this hypocritical? Do they think they are "bribing" G-d with one day of good behavior and thereby gain absolution for the whole year?

And are religious Jews sincere in their confession and repentance on Yom Kippur? When we beat our chests and recite "We have sinned before you with dishonesty" are we really guaranteeing that we will not be dishonest again all year? What about when we say "We have sinned before you with gossip?" We promise never to gossip again?

Where is your truth?

A story is told of a chassidic businessman. He felt uncomfortable wearing chassidic garb among his business associates so during the week he'd wear modern clothes and wore the traditional chassidic frock coat only on Shabbat.

One week he decided that he was being hypocritical. He did not dress like a chassid all week. Why should he fool his chassidic friends by dressing like them on the weekends? He thought about it and decided to stop the charade. The next Shabbat he showed up in shul wearing his business suit. When he stood before his Rebbe he felt a need to justify himself. "Rebbe, I've decided to stop fooling everyone."

The Rebbe smiled and said "Did you think I didn't know that you wear modern dress all week? I figured that all week you were fooling

them and you showed your true self here. But now I realize who you were fooling all along..."

Not hypocrisy

This, in essence, is the question: is our behavior on Yom Kippur the lie or maybe all year long we are lying and on Yom Kippur the truth comes out.

It does not take any special perception to realize that when people go to the synagogue and pray on Yom Kippur they are not doing so out of a need to fool anyone. Just observe their demeanor on Yom Kippur and see that a deep part of their soul is aroused. On Yom Kippur we do not lie, not to ourselves and not to our G-d.

On Yom Kippur our inner truth comes out. The rest of the year we put on a show, except that we ourselves do not realize it and think it's our real self. That's why we need Yom Kippur - to remind us that the way we act all year is not who we really are.

Just to be a Jew

Yom Kippur is our moment of truth. On this holy day we reveal who we truly are. All year we pursue external and superficial desires. All the conflicts and spats we get into during the year are a reflection of this superficiality. We forget that in truth we are one and the divisions between us are artificial. On Yom Kippur the truth comes out and we feel part of one united people, gathered together with the same hopes and prayers for the coming year.

This is true on a personal level as well. We get so caught up in our day-to-day struggles



and worry only about the here and now. On Yom Kippur we set that aside to focus on what is eternal.

When Yom Kippur comes we remember that we are Jews and our place is in the synagogue. We come to be cleansed and

purified, to turn to G-d and simply let our soul express itself.

If only these elevated feelings would stay with us all year.

May you be sealed for a good year.

Yom Kippur | What Do We Do?

Eve of Yom Kippur

Sunday, 9 Tishrei, September 27

Forgiveness. For sins we have committed against other people it is not enough to pray in the synagogue. We must approach the person we wronged and ask forgiveness. If we have caused someone financial loss, we must repay it. On the other hand, sins against G-d can be atoned through regret, prayer and fasting.

Kapparot. Early in the morning on the eve of Yom Kippur we perform the Kapparot ritual. We take a live chicken (male for male, female for female) and recite the Kapparot liturgy found in the prayer book. It can also be done earlier, in the days between Rosh Hashana and Yom Kippur. The chicken is slaughtered and its meat given to the poor. Kapparot can also be done with money for charity rather than a chicken.

Tzedakah. It is customary to give extra tzedakah before Yom Kippur because “tzedakah saves from death” and arouses G-d’s compassion.

Food. It is a mitzvah to eat and drink the day before Yom Kippur so as not to enter the fast hungry.

Immersion. It is customary to immerse in a mikvah to enter the holiday in purity and holiness.

Afternoon prayer. We should make an effort to pray Minchah in the early afternoon. At the end of the prayer we recite viduy (confession).

Seudah Hamafseket. Shortly before the fast begins we eat a festive meal. From then on we may not eat until the following night.

We finish this meal shortly before candle lighting.

Memorial candle. On Erev Yom Kippur we light a “living candle” which burns for 24 hours. (A “neshama” candle is used but it is not in memory of the souls of the departed.) At the conclusion of Yom Kippur, during Havdalah, we make a blessing over this candle.

Candle lighting. Before the holiday begins women and girls light candles. For candlelighting times see page 25.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments, and commanded us to kindle the Yom Kippur light.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Blessing the children. Before going to synagogue it is customary for the father to bless his children.

For boys: “May G-d make you like Ephraim and Menashe.”

For girls: “May G-d make you like Sarah, Rebecca, Rachel and Leah.”

And G-d spoke to Moses, saying: Speak to Aaron and his sons saying, so shall you bless the children of Israel. Say to them: ‘May G-d bless you and keep you. May G-d shine His countenance upon you and be gracious to you. May G-d raise His face to you and grant you peace.’ And they shall place My name on the children of Israel, and I will bless them.

While it is still daytime, men wrap themselves in a tallit and say the blessing on it.



Rest from work. On Yom Kippur all work is forbidden, just like on Shabbat.

Soul searching. On Yom Kippur we should reflect on our deeds and express our regret for any improper actions and make good resolutions to correct them for the coming year. It is preferable not to suffice with a general resolution to be better but to make specific commitments.

The confession. When a person seeks to do teshuvah, two steps are required: sincere regret for the past and a confession of past sins. Our sages have composed the “Al Chet” a long list of all possible sins. On Yom Kippur we confess our sins (to G-d, not to our fellow man), accept upon ourselves not to sin again and ask G-d for forgiveness.

Fast of Yom Kippur

Monday, 10 Tishrei, September 28

Fasting. The central and most important mitzvah of the day is fasting. It is forbidden to eat or drink or even to rinse out the mouth or brush teeth. It is also forbidden to wash one's hands or body, to wear leather shoes, use creams or oils on the skin or engage in marital intimacy.

Yizkor. In the morning, after reading the Torah, we mention the souls of our dear departed.

Havdalah. After nightfall (see page 25), we make havdalah on a cup of wine, and make a blessing over fire that was prepared before the holiday.

Indeed, G-d is my deliverance; I am confident and shall not fear, for G-d the L-rd is my strength and song, and He has been a help to me. You shall draw water with joy from the wellsprings of deliverance. Deliverance is the L-rd's; may Your blessing be upon Your people forever. The L-rd of hosts is with us; the G-d of Jacob is our everlasting stronghold. L-rd of hosts, happy is the man who trusts in You. L-rd, deliver us; may the King answer us on the day we call.

For the Jews there was light and joy, gladness and honor—so let it be with us! I will raise the cup of deliverance and invoke the name of the L-rd. Attention, Gentlemen! Blessed are You, L-rd our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine. Blessed are You, L-rd our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the lights of fire. Blessed are You, L-rd our G-d, King of the universe, who makes a distinction between sacred and mundane, between light and darkness, between Israel and the nations, between the Seventh Day and the six workdays. Blessed are You, L-rd, who makes a distinction between sacred and mundane.

Only afterwards do we eat and drink.

Preparing for Sukkot. On the night after Yom Kippur it is customary to begin the preparations for building the sukkah to start with mitzvot immediately after the fast.

Yom Kippur



What It's All About

🕯️ This is the holiest day of the year, a day of fasting, purification, forgiveness and uniting with G-d.

🕯️ Yom Kippur is on the 10th of Tishrei. Its source is in the Torah (Vayikra 16:29-30): “In the seventh month, on the tenth of the month, you shall afflict yourselves... Before the Lord, you shall be cleansed from all your sins.”

🕯️ Fasting is the main mitzvah of Yom Kippur. The fast begins at sunset on the eve of Yom Kippur and concludes at nightfall the following day.

🕯️ This is the day that our judgment is sealed

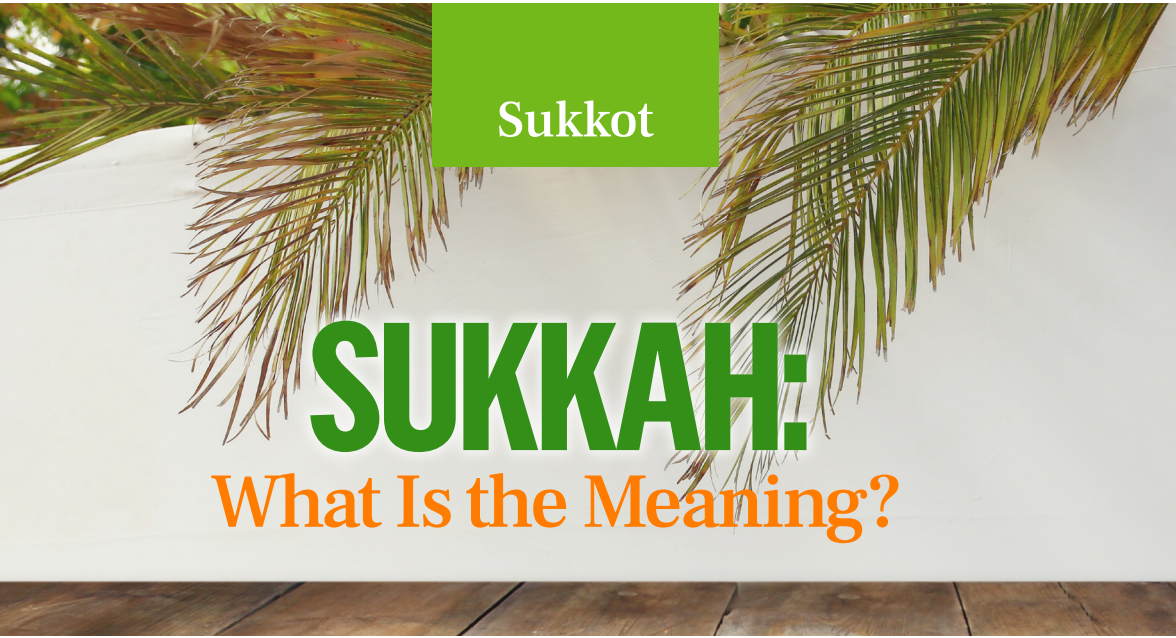
for the year to come.

🕯️ Yom Kippur is the only day on which we pray five prayers: Evening, morning, mussaf, afternoon prayer, and ne'ilah (closing of the gates).

🕯️ On this day, Moses descended from Mount Sinai after 40 additional days of prayer to atone for the sin of the golden calf. On this day G-d said, “I have forgiven them as you have said.”

🕯️ This is the only day of the year that the High Priest would enter the Holy of Holies in the Temple.





Sukkot

SUKKAH:

What Is the Meaning?

Imagine trying to explain the meaning of sukkah to someone who has never heard of it before.

“Sukkah... sukkah... it’s like a summer bungalow with a roof of branches. We spend seven days outdoors in the sukkah.”

Sounds like a mini-vacation, or a camping trip. But why in middle of fall when a winter chill has already started to enter the air?

We dwell in huts to commemorate our exodus from Egypt – which took place in the spring - when G-d protected us from the elements with His clouds of glory. But if we were to dwell in the sukkah during balmy weather, it would look like we were doing it for our own pleasure. When we go out into the sukkah in rainy or frigid weather – it is clear that we are doing it to fulfill G-d’s commandment.

There is another reason that we leave our homes to sit in the sukkah during this season. Sukkot is also called the “harvest holiday,” when we celebrate the abundant crops of the summer.

The grain has already been gathered, the grapes have been crushed and the barrels are filled with wine. Such bounty can give a person a feeling of self-satisfaction, that their hard work brought all these benefits.

Therefore, during this season of abundance we leave our comfortable, well-appointed homes to dwell in the humble sukkah. The sukkah is open to everyone – friends and neighbors. Even a passerby may enter our sukkah to taste something, have a drink and chat. Sitting in a sukkah gives us a sense of proportion. Rich or poor, our sukkot are remarkably alike. Sukkot is a time to set aside the frills and focus on the essentials.

The All-Embracing Sukkah

The teachings of Chassidut give us a deeper understanding of the mitzvah of sukkah. Other mitzvot are done with a specific limb of the body. The



mitzvah of tefillin, for example, is on the arm and head. The Shema prayer is said with the lips, and so on. The mitzvah of sukkah, in contrast, envelops the entire person. When we sit in the sukkah we are completely surrounded by the mitzvah and all limbs of our body participate in it. Not only this but the mitzvah of sukkah includes also our clothing, our table and chairs, our dishes, our cutlery. Every item that we use for the sukkah becomes part of the mitzvah. Sitting in the sukkah is like getting a big hug from our Father in heaven. This is how Chassidic teachings interpret the verse in Song of Songs: "His left arm is under my head, His right arm embraces me." The left arm represents judgment and awe. These are the Days of Awe, with which we begin Tishrei. Then we reach the stage of being embraced with the right arm - which represents G-d's closeness and love. This warm embrace is the sukkah.

A Jew's Physical Life

On Sukkot G-d hugs us close to Him with a loving embrace. He says to us: My children, I love you not only in the synagogue, not only when you pray and study Torah. I love you even when you are eating and drinking, celebrating, hosting friends. Sit in My sukkah, enjoy, celebrate, and every moment that you spend in the sukkah is another mitzvah which binds you to Me!

This is the amazing lesson we take from the mitzvah of sukkah. This mitzvah gives us the power to sanctify and elevate our mundane lives throughout the year. Our physical life is important too! When we eat or drink, work for a living or attend to our physical needs, we are connected to G-d and are performing a mitzvah no less than when we pray and study. This is the power of sukkah and that is why this mitzvah is so precious. It gives us a wealth of happiness and satisfaction – "And you shall rejoice on your holiday."

Sukkot



What It's All About

🕯️ Sukkot is a holiday from the Torah which we celebrate for seven days. The first day, the 15th of Tishrei, is a holiday, while the following days are "intermediate days."

🕯️ The Torah calls the holiday "Chag Ha'asif- the harvest holiday" and "Sukkot" because we dwell in huts. In our prayers we call the holiday "Zman simchateinu -The time of our rejoicing."

🕯️ There are two main mitzvot of Sukkot - to dwell in the sukkah and to bless the four species.

🕯️ Sukkot was one of three holidays when the Jews would go up to Jerusalem, to the Holy Temple. Thousands would also participate in the joyous celebration called "Simchat Beit HaShoeva" that took place in the evenings of the intermediate days of Sukkot.



Sukkot | What Do We Do?

Eve of Sukkot

Friday, 14 Tishrei, October 2

Preparing the Four Species. On the afternoon before Sukkot begins it is customary to go into the sukkah to bind together the lulav with the three hadassim (at minimum) and two aravot.

Candle lighting. Before Shabbat and the holiday, women and girls light candles. The daughters should light before the mother. For candlelighting times see page 25.

Recite the following blessings:

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments, and commanded us to kindle the Shabbat and Yom Tov light.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of

the Universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Kiddush. During kiddush we add two blessings: "To dwell in the sukkah" and "He grants us life."

Prepare the meal of the supernal King.

The sixth day, And the heavens and the earth all their hosts were completed. And G-d finished by the Seventh Day His work which He had done, and He rested on the Seventh Day from all His work which He had done. And G-d blessed the Seventh Day and made it holy, for on it He rested from all His work which G-d created to function.

Attention Gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has chosen us from among all nations, raised us above all languages, and made us holy through His commandments. And You, Lord our G-d, have given us in love this Shabbat for rest and festivals for rejoicing, holidays and seasons for gladness, this Shabbat day and this day of The Festival of Sukkot and this festival of holy assembly, the season of our rejoicing, in love, a holy assembly, commemorating the Exodus from Egypt. For You have chosen us and sanctified us from among all the nations, and Your holy Shabbat and Festivals in love and goodwill, in joy and gladness, You have given us as a heritage. Blessed are You, Lord, who sanctifies the Shabbat and Israel and the festive seasons.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has sanctified us with

Building a Sukkah:

Who? Anyone can build a sukkah. Still, check with your rabbi to ensure that your sukkah is kosher.

When? Start building your sukkah as soon as Yom Kippur ends.

Where? A sukkah is a hut built to provide shade. It must sit beneath the open sky - not under a roof, porch or tree branch.

How big? The sukkah must have two and a half walls, at minimum. The walls of the house can be included as part of the sukkah.

Out of what? The sukkah can be built out of any material as long as it is strong and stable. The schach (roof covering) of the sukkah must be from plant matter (wood or branches) that has never been used for any other purpose.



The Four Species Shake

The special Sukkot mitzvah of the Four Species - the etrog (citron), lulav (palm branch), hadassim (myrtle branches) and aravot (willow branches) - is a very special one and symbolic of unity and harmony.

We make a blessing on the four species each day of Sukkot, except for Shabbat.

1. Take the lulav wrapped with three myrtle twigs and two willow branches and hold those in your right hand.
2. Say the blessing: **Blessed are You, G-d our G-d, King of the universe, Who has sanctified us with His commandments and commanded us to take up the lulav.**

3. Take the etrog in the left hand. The first time (each Sukkot) that we do this mitzvah, the following blessing is said (while holding the etrog in the left hand): **Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.**
4. Hold the lulav and etrog together in both hands and move/shake them three times in each direction (north, south, east, west, up and down), signifying that G-d is everywhere.

His commandments and commanded us to dwell in the sukkah.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Sitting in the sukkah. On the first night of Sukkot there is a mitzvah to eat at least a k'zait (1 oz.) of challah or bread in the sukkah. At the beginning of the meal, after Hamotzi and before eating (except for the one making Kiddush) we recite the following blessing:

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments and commanded us to dwell in the sukkah.

From now until after Shmini Atzeret we eat all meals in the sukkah. Every time we eat in the sukkah, this blessing is said.

Simchat Beis Hashoevah. There is a special mitzvah to rejoice on Sukkot. It is customary to arrange a celebration each night of Sukkot with song and dancing to commemorate the ritual water drawing in the Holy Temple which was accompanied with joy and celebration.

First day of Sukkot

Shabbat, 15 Tishrei, October 3

Blessing the lulav. When the first day of Sukkot falls on Shabbat, the blessing on the lulav and etrog is not made.

Hoshanot. When the first day of Sukkot falls on Shabbat, Hoshanot are not said.

Kiddush and holiday meal. In the afternoon we celebrate the holiday with a festive meal. Before the meal we make kiddush with a special blessing for Sukkot.

This is the meal of the holy Ancient One.

Remember the Shabbat day to sanctify it. Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is Shabbat for the Lord of your God; you shall not do any work - you, your son or your daughter, your manservant or your maidservant, or your cattle, or the stranger within your gates. For in six days the Lord made the heavens, the earth, the sea, and all that is in them, and rested on the seventh day - Therefore the Lord blessed the Shabbat day and made it holy.



Four Species, Four Types

Each of the four species that we use on Sukkot symbolizes a different type of person. The mitzvah symbolizes bonding with different people in unity.

Etrog (citron): It has a pleasant fragrance and flavor and represents Jews who possess both good deeds and Torah knowledge.

Lulav (palm branch): It has a pleasant taste (dates) but no fragrance to symbolize Jews with good deeds but little Torah knowledge.

Hadas (myrtle branch): It has a pleasant fragrance but no flavor to symbolize those who are strong in Torah study but not in good deeds.

Aravah (willow): It has neither a good taste nor fragrance to symbolize those who do not study Torah or observe mitzvot.

The Torah says: With an etrog alone we cannot fulfill the mitzvah nor with the lulav or hadas together. We must include the aravah as well even though it lacks both taste and fragrance and bind it with the other types. This symbolizes the unity of the Jewish people. Bringing all the kinds together represents our unity as a nation - despite our external differences.

These are the festivals of the Lord, holy assemblies, which you shall proclaim at their appointed times.

Attention, gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments and commanded us to dwell in the sukkah.

Second night of Sukkot

Motzei Shabbat, 15 Tishrei, October 3

Candle lighting. We light candles after night fall, before the meal. We use a flame that was lit before the holiday as it is forbidden to light a new flame on Yom Tov. For candlelighting times see pages 25.

Recite the following blessings:

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments, and commanded us to kindle the Yom Tov light.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Kiddush and holiday meal. Before the meal at night we make a blessing over wine, with the same blessing

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments and commanded us to dwell in the sukkah.

Second day of Sukkot

Sunday, 16 Tishrei, October 4

Blessing on lulav. One of the main mitzvot of Sukkot is to bless the lulav and etrog. We are particular to make the blessing inside the sukkah, however, the blessing can be made anywhere. (Details of the mitzvah can be found on page 18.)



The Ushpizin:

In the book of Zohar it is written that when the Jewish people enter the sukkah they merit to receive the Shechinah. Seven loyal shepherds of the Jewish people descend from Gan Eden and join us in the sukkah as ushpizin, guests.

On the first day we are honored with a visit from Abraham, on the second day, Isaac; the third day, Jacob; and so on – Moses, Aaron, Joseph and David. It is also written that the ushpizin love to see us hosting guests in our sukkah and then they bless all the participants with a wealth of blessings.

Hoshanot. After Hallel each morning of Sukkot we recite a liturgy of special requests known as Hoshanot, while marching around the bimah, holding our lulav and etrog.

Holiday meal. We have a festive meal on the second day of the holiday as well. Before the meal we recite kiddush on a cup of wine.

Prepare the meal of the King, the complete delight of the holy King. This is the meal of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Shechinah.

These are the festivals of the Lord, holy assemblies, which you shall proclaim at their appointed times.

Attention, gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments and commanded us to dwell in the sukkah.

Havdalah. At the conclusion of the holiday, havdalah is recited on a cup of wine. The blessings on the spices and candle are omitted.

Chol Hamoed Sukkot (Intermediate Days)

**Monday - Friday, 17 - 21 Tishrei,
October 5 - October 9**

Blessing on lulav. Each day of the holiday except for Shabbat we perform

the mitzvah of blessing the lulav.

Eating in the sukkah. Each day of Sukkot through Shmini Atzeret we eat all our meals in the sukkah. Before eating we recite the blessing of Lesheiv baSukkah (to dwell in the sukkah).

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments and commanded us to dwell in the sukkah.

Other observances. During the intermediate days of Sukkot we do not put on tefillin and we do not do any non-essential labor. In our prayers and in Grace after Meals we recite the prayer of Yaaleh v'Yavo (May they ascend and come).

Hoshana Rabbah

Friday, 21 Tishrei, October 9

The final decree. The last day of Sukkot is called Hoshana Rabbah. On this day the verdict of Yom Kippur is finalized.

Staying up all night. On Sukkot G-d determines how much water He will send us all year. Since our lives depend on water it is customary to stay up all night on Hoshana Rabbah (Thursday night) to read the book of Devarim (Deuteronomy) and Tehillim (Psalms).

Binding aravot. After the morning prayer we circle the bimah seven times with our lulav and etrog and at the end we beat the ground with five aravot (willow branches) bound together to mitigate any evil decrees.



This Is Your Holiday!

This is not the holiday of the scholar. Each of us rejoice on Simchat Torah regardless of our level of knowledge in Torah. We celebrate the very fact that we are Jews who have the Torah.

There is a well-known tale of a simple Jew who was once seen dancing with all his might on Simchat Torah. He was asked, "Why are you so happy? You do not learn much Torah all year long." The man answered, "And when my brother marries off a child do I not rejoice with him?" However, his answer misses the point. Simchat Torah is not a holiday for scholars with the rest of us as onlookers. It is our personal holiday.

A Closed Torah

The meaning of Simchat Torah can be inferred from the way we celebrate it. Torah is an intellectual study. You would assume that the way to celebrate the completion of the Torah would be to spend more time studying. Rabbis and yeshivah heads would deliver their most complex lectures and insights. But we celebrate in a different manner entirely. We do not study at all but dance and rejoice with the Torah as it is wrapped with its cover.

This shows us that our celebration is not of our intellectual achievement in studying Torah. We rejoice in the fact that we are Jews and that we have a Torah. This feeling is shared by every Jew whether he is a great scholar or knows very little. The Torah belongs to all of us. We all sense the holiness and preciousness of Torah and we all rejoice equally.

Drawing Inspiration for the Whole Year

Multitudes flock to the synagogue on Simchat Torah for the celebration. Fathers carry their children, young men dance with their full strength and old men liven the synagogue with the traditional songs. We all feel our essential bond to the Torah and to G-d. Our hearts open with love for G-d and the soul within us feels refreshed. Simchat Torah is a time to pack in enough inspiration, love and joy to last us the entire year.



Shmini Atzeret | What Do We Do?

Eve of Shmini Atzeret

Friday, Tishrei 21, October 9

Candle lighting. Before Shabbat and the holiday, women and girls light candles. The daughters should light before the mother. For candlelighting times see page 25.

Recite the following blessings:

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments, and commanded us to kindle the Shabbat and Yom Tov light.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Hakafot . On the night of Shmini Atzeret we dance with the Torah around the synagogue to express our solidarity with the Jews of Israel who celebrate the holiday for only one day and are dancing tonight.

Kiddush and holiday meal. At night we eat a festive meal in the sukkah. We make a blessing over the wine and recite the Kiddush. We do not make the blessing for sitting in the sukkah.

Attention, gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe who creates the fruit of the vine.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has chosen us from among all nations, raised us above all tongues, and made us holy through His commandments. And You, Lord our G-d, have given us in love, festivals for rejoicing, holidays and seasons for gladness, this day of Shmini Atzeret the festival and this festival of holy assembly, the season of our rejoicing, a holy assembly commemorating the exodus from Egypt. For You have chosen us and sanctified us from among all the nations, and Your holy festivals in joy and gladness, You have given us as a heritage. Blessed are You Lord, who

sanctifies Israel and the festival seasons.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Shmini Atzeret

Shabbat, Tishrei 22, October 10

Yizkor. After the Torah reading of the first day in the morning we say a special prayer to remember the souls of our dear departed.

Prayer for rain. After Yizkor we say the Prayer for Rain in which we request that G-d send abundant rain for blessing during the upcoming year. From this time on we begin to say "He causes the wind to blow and the rain to fall" in our prayers.

Kiddush and festive meal. In the afternoon we eat a holiday meal. Before the meal recite the kiddush. We do not make the blessing for sitting in the sukkah.

This is the meal of the holy Ancient One.

Remember the Shabbat day to sanctify it. Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is Shabbat for the Lord of your God; you shall not do any work - you, your son or your daughter, your manservant or your maidservant, or your cattle, or the stranger within your gates. For in six days the Lord made the heavens, the earth, the sea, and all that is in them, and rested on the seventh day-

Therefore the Lord blessed the Shabbat day and made it holy.

These are the festivals of the Lord, holy assemblies, which you shall proclaim at their appointed times.

Attention, gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Shmini Atzeret



What It's All About

☞ Shmini Atzeret is the eighth day of Sukkot but is actually its own holiday as is written in the Torah "The eighth day shall be Atzeret for you, you shall not perform any work."

☞ This holiday expresses G-d's love for us. After completing the seven days of Sukkot in Jerusalem G-d says to His children, "Stay with me one more day because it's difficult for Me to part from you!"



Simchat Torah | What Do We Do?

Eve of Simchat Torah

Motzei Shabbat, 22 Tishrei, October 10

Candle lighting. We light candles after night fall, before the meal. We use a flame that was lit before the holiday as it is forbidden to light a new flame on Yom Tov. For candlelighting times see page 25.

Recite the following blessings:

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments, and commanded us to kindle the Yom Tov light.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the Universe, who has granted us life, sustained us and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Hakafot. After evening services we dance around the synagogue holding the Torahs. It is customary to remove all the Torah scrolls from the ark and the congregants are invited one by one to hold a Torah and dance with it.

Kiddush and holiday meal. At night it is a mitzvah to eat a festive meal. We begin with kiddush over wine.

Attention Gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who has chosen us from among all nations, raised us above all languages, and made us holy through His commandments. And You, Lord our G-d, have given us in love festivals for rejoicing, holidays and seasons for gladness, this day of Shmini Atzeret the festival and this festival of holy assembly, the season of our rejoicing, a holy assembly, commemorating the Exodus from Egypt. For You have chosen us and sanctified us from among all the nations, and Your holy Festivals, in joy and gladness, You have given us as a heritage. Blessed are You, Lord, who sanctifies

Israel and the festive seasons.

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who created the lights of fire.

Glance at the festival lights; then continue:

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who makes a distinction between sacred and profane, between light and darkness, between Israel and the nations, between the Seventh Day and the six work days; between the holiness of the Shabbat and the holiness of the Festival You have made a distinction, and have sanctified the Seventh day above the six work days. You have set apart and made holy Your people Israel with Your holiness. Blessed are You, Lord, who makes a distinction between holy and holy.

Simchat Torah

Sunday, 23 Tishrei, October 11

Hakafot. After the morning prayers we again dance Hakafot (lit. "circles") in honor of the Torah.

Aliyot to the Torah. On Simchat Torah it is customary for every male to be called up to the Torah. Even young children should be called up (with an adult) in a special aliyah just for children.

Kiddush and holiday meal. In the afternoon we eat a festive meal which begins with kiddush.

Prepare the meal of the King, the complete delight of the holy King. This is the meal of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Shechinah.

These are the festivals of the Lord, holy assemblies, which you shall proclaim at their appointed times.

Attention, gentlemen!

Blessed are You, Lord our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Havdalah. At the conclusion of the holiday, havdalah is recited on a cup of wine. The blessings on the spices and candle are omitted.

Simchat Torah



What It's All About

🔊 This holiday is called Simchat Torah because we complete a full cycle of Torah reading and begin again from Bereishit.

🔊 By the reading of "Vzot HaBracha" all the males in the congregation are honored with an aliyah l'Torah.

🔊 The Chanah Torah is honored with the aliyah of concluding the reading of the whole Torah. Immediately, the Chanah Bereishit begins reading the Torah anew to symbolize the continuation and the cycle of the Torah.

